

MODULE 3

LESSON 1: Communication Strategies in IT Dialogue

Communication strategies are techniques used to make communication **clear, effective, and understandable**, especially when people encounter problems, misunderstandings, or unfamiliar technical terms.

Communication strategies are important because IT professionals often communicate with clients, programmers, designers, network administrators, technicians, and users who may have different levels of technical knowledge.

1. ASKING FOR CLARIFICATION

This strategy is used when you **do not understand what someone means**. Instead of guessing, you ask for more information.

Useful expressions:

- “Could you clarify that?”
- “What do you mean by...?”
- “Could you explain that again?”
- “Do you mean that...?”

Example:

Client: The website is not working properly.

IT Staff: Could you clarify what you mean by “not working properly”?

Client: The login button does not respond when I click it.

2. ASKING FOR REPETITION

Use this strategy when you **did not hear or understand something clearly**.

Useful expressions:

- “Could you repeat that, please?”
- “Sorry, could you say that again?”
- “Could you repeat the last part?”
- “I didn’t catch that.”

Example:

Technician: Please enter the IP address 192.168.10.25.

User: Sorry, could you repeat the IP address?

Technician: Sure. It is 192.168.10.25.

3. PARAPHRASING

Paraphrasing means expressing another person's idea using **different words** to make sure you understand it correctly.

Useful expressions:

- “So, you mean that...”
- “In other words,...”
- “If I understand you correctly,...”
- “So, what you're saying is...”

Example:

User: My computer becomes very slow whenever I open several applications.

Technician: So, you mean the computer slows down when multiple programs are running?

User: Yes, exactly.

4. CONFIRMING UNDERSTANDING

This strategy is used to **check whether you understood the information correctly**.

Useful expressions:

- "Is that correct?"
- "Do I understand you correctly?"
- "So, the problem is...?"
- "Let me make sure I understand."

Example:

Programmer: The application crashes when the user uploads a large file.

Team Leader: Let me make sure I understand. The problem only occurs when the uploaded file is large, correct?

Programmer: Yes, that's correct.

5. GIVING EXAMPLES

Examples can make **technical information easier to understand**, especially for non-technical users.

Useful expressions:

- "For example,..."
- "For instance,..."
- "Such as..."
- "To give you an example..."

Example:

Technician: You need to update your operating system regularly.

User: Why is that important?

Technician: For example, updates can fix security vulnerabilities and improve system performance.

6. USING SIMPLE LANGUAGE

IT professionals should avoid unnecessary technical jargon when speaking with people who are not familiar with IT.

Technical: "Your device has insufficient RAM and excessive background processes."

Simpler: "Your computer has limited memory, and too many programs are running in the background."

Dialogue:

User: Why is my laptop so slow?

Technician: Several programs are running at the same time. This uses too much memory.

User: Oh, I understand now.

7. USING TECHNICAL TERMS WHEN APPROPRIATE

Although simple language is useful, technical terms are necessary when communicating with **IT professionals**.

Example:

Network Administrator: Have you checked the DHCP configuration?

IT Technician: Yes. The DHCP server is assigning incorrect IP addresses.

Here, technical terms such as **DHCP, server, and IP addresses** are appropriate because both speakers understand them.

8. ASKING FOR CONFIRMATION

This strategy ensures that the listener has **received and understood instructions correctly**.

Useful expressions:

- “Can you confirm that?”
- “Could you confirm the settings?”
- “Is everything clear?”
- “Have you completed that step?”

Example:

Technician: Please restart the router after saving the new configuration.

User: Okay.

Technician: Can you confirm that you have saved the configuration first?

User: Yes, I have.

9. CORRECTING MISUNDERSTANDINGS

Sometimes communication problems happen because one person misunderstands information. Politely correcting the misunderstanding helps avoid mistakes.

Useful expressions:

- “Actually,…”
- “Sorry, that’s not what I meant.”
- “Let me correct that.”
- “I mean…”

Example:

Designer: The client wants us to delete the entire database.

Developer: Are you sure?

Designer: Sorry, that’s not what I meant. The client wants us to delete only the old customer records.

10. USING NONVERBAL COMMUNICATION

Communication is not always about words. In IT workplaces, **eye contact, facial expressions, gestures, tone of voice, and body language** can also help communicate meaning.

Example:

During a troubleshooting session, an IT technician points to the network cable and says:

Technician: Please check this cable first.

The technician's **gesture toward the cable** makes the instruction easier to understand.

LESSON 2: Using Inversion in Formal IT Reports

What is Inversion?

Inversion means changing the usual word order of a sentence.

Normally, English sentences follow: **Subject + Verb**

Example: The system **was** slow.

With **inversion**, the order changes, usually putting an **auxiliary verb before the subject**:
Never was the system so slow.

In formal IT reports, inversion is used to make writing sound **more formal, professional, and emphatic**.

▪ Why Use Inversion in IT Reports?

Inversion can help you:

- make a report sound **formal**
- emphasize an important finding
- highlight a problem or condition
- make recommendations sound stronger
- present information in a professional way

Compare:

Normal: The system has never experienced this problem before.

Inversion: Never has the system experienced this problem before.

- The second sentence sounds more formal and emphasizes “**never**.”

▪ BASIC PATTERN OF INVERSION

A simple pattern is:

Negative/limiting expression + auxiliary verb + subject + main verb

Example:

Normal: The server has never experienced such a problem.

Inversion: **Never has the server experienced** such a problem.

Notice the change:

Normal: The server **has** experienced...

Inversion: **Never has** the server experienced...

▪ COMMON EXPRESSIONS USED WITH INVERSION

Some expressions commonly used in formal writing are:

- **Never**
- **Rarely**
- **Seldom**
- **Hardly**
- **Not only**
- **Under no circumstances**
- **Only after**
- **Only when**
- **Not until**

- **No sooner**

These expressions can be placed at the beginning of a sentence to create inversion.

1. Inversion with “Never”

- **Never** means **at no time**.

Normal: The application has never crashed during testing.

Inversion: **Never has the application crashed during testing.**

IT Report Example: Never has the database shown such a high error rate during previous tests.
This sounds more formal than: The database has never shown such a high error rate during previous tests.

The technician has never failed in this challenge.

Never has the technician failed this challenge.

2. Inversion with “Rarely”

- **Rarely** means **not often**.

Normal: The server experiences downtime during regular operations.

Inversion: Rarely does the server experience downtime during regular operations.

IT Report Example: Rarely does the network experience this level of traffic.
This emphasizes that the situation is unusual.

3. Inversion with “Seldom”

- **Seldom** has almost the same meaning as **rarely**.

Normal: The system encounters this type of error.

Inversion: Seldom does the system encounter this type of error.

IT Report Example: Seldom does the application require manual intervention after deployment.

4. Inversion with “Not Only”

-**Not only... but also...** is useful when you want to emphasize **two important results or advantages**.

Normal: The update improved security and increased system performance.

Inversion: Not only did the update improve security, but it also increased system performance.

IT Report Example: Not only did the software update fix the security vulnerability, but it also improved application performance.

Pattern:

Not only + auxiliary verb + subject + verb, but + subject + also + verb

5. Inversion with “Only After”

- Use **only after** when something happened **after another action or event**.

Normal: The technician discovered the problem after checking the server logs.

Inversion: Only after checking the server logs did the technician discover the problem.

IT Report Example: Only after analyzing the network traffic did the administrator identify the source of the connection problem.

-This is useful when describing **troubleshooting procedures**.

6. Inversion with “Only When”

- Use **only when** to emphasize a condition.

Normal: The system displays the warning when the storage capacity reaches 90%.

Inversion: Only when the storage capacity reaches 90% does the system display the warning.

IT Report Example: Only when the server reaches its maximum capacity does the system generate an alert.

7. Inversion with “Not Until”

- **Not until** means **something did not happen before a particular time or event**.

Normal: The technician identified the problem after reviewing the logs.

Inversion: Not until the technician reviewed the logs did he identify the problem.

IT Report Example: Not until the software was updated did the application function properly. This is useful when describing **when a problem was finally solved**.

8. Inversion with “Under No Circumstances”

- This expression means **never or in no situation**.
- It is very formal and can be useful for **security rules and IT policies**.

Normal: Users must not share their passwords.

Inversion: Under no circumstances should users share their passwords.

IT Report Example: Under no circumstances should administrators disclose user passwords to unauthorized personnel.

9. Inversion with “Hardly... When”

- This structure shows that **one event happened almost immediately before another event**.

Pattern: **Hardly + had + subject + past participle + when + event**

Normal: The technician had just restarted the server when the system crashed again.

Inversion: Hardly had the technician restarted the server when the system crashed again.

IT Report Example: Hardly had the server been restarted when another system error occurred.

10. Inversion with “No Sooner... Than”

- This is similar to **hardly... when**.

Normal: The administrator completed the update, and immediately afterward, the system restarted.

Inversion: No sooner had the administrator completed the update than the system restarted.

IT Report Example: No sooner had the security patch been installed than the system detected another vulnerability.

■ Important Rule: Use the Correct Auxiliary Verb

When using inversion, the auxiliary verb depends on the tense.

- **Present Simple**
Use **do/does**.
Rarely **does** the server experience downtime.
- **Past Simple**
Use **did**.
Rarely **did** the system experience errors.

- **Present Perfect**
Use **has/have**.
Never **has** the application experienced this problem.
- **Past Perfect**
Use **had**.
Hardly **had** the technician restarted the server when it crashed.
- **Modal verbs**
Put the modal before the subject.
Under no circumstances **should** users share their passwords.

EASY COMPARISON

Normal Sentence

The server rarely crashes.
The application has never failed during testing.
The update improved security and performance.
The technician found the problem after checking the logs.
Users should never share their passwords.
The system worked properly after the patch was installed.

Inverted Sentence

Rarely does the server crash.
Never has the application failed during testing.
Not only did the update improve security, but it also improved performance.
Only after checking the logs did the technician find the problem.
Under no circumstances should users share their passwords.
Not until the patch was installed did the system work properly.

Roleplay Analytic Rubric (30 Points Total)

Criterion	Exemplary (5–6 pts)	Proficient (3–4 pts)	Developing / Novice (0–2 pts)
1. Character Embodiment	Stays in character seamlessly with authentic tone and demeanor.	Stays in character consistently with rare, minor lapses.	Frequently breaks character or shows little commitment.
2. Content Knowledge	Accurately weaves core facts and skills into dialogue.	Shows solid grasp of facts; minor content gaps.	Incorrect or missing relevant content; off-topic.
3. Communication	Clear, expressive voice with natural gestures and body language.	Clear and audible, though delivery lacks expression or energy.	Hard to understand; monotone voice or minimal effort.
4. Interaction & Listening	Listens actively and responds dynamically to partners.	Responds well to partners, though answers feel scripted.	Ignores partner cues or dominates/shuts down dialogue.
5. Scenario Resolution	Actively works toward and satisfies the scenario's goal.	Addresses scenario goals, but resolution feels predictable.	Wanders off-topic; fails to resolve the scenario.